

HEMANT MISHRA

ACCOMPLISHMENT
She leads the largest alcobev company in India

Beverage Queen

Hina Nagarajan, *58*
MD & CEO, Diageo India; Member, Diageo Global Executive Committee; Non-Executive Director, BP Plc

IN 2021, WHEN HINA NAGARAJAN TOOK OVER AS CEO OF DIAGEO INDIA, her appointment caused more than a stir, both in the alcobev industry as well as in the country. "It piqued interest, with a lot of media reports complimenting me as a woman CEO in the alcobev industry and my phone and LinkedIn were abuzz with congratulatory messages. Although over the years, there has been a shift in the narrative from being a 'woman leader' to a 'business leader'," she says.

A strong advocate of creating opportunities for women, Hina contributes to Inclusion & Diversity Programmes at work. It is this inclusiveness that is as much a personal goal as now a quasi-official workplace ethic at the company. "As a woman leading the largest alcobev company in India, I want to shape the category and open it up to more diverse talents and consumers who enjoy experiences that are unique."

Diageo India aims to have an overall strength of 50 per cent women by 2025. "To achieve this, we have taken a top-down approach to driving change by hiring women in varied leadership roles," says Hina, who has spent over 30 years in the FMCG industry.

Apart from managing Diageo in India, Hina also sits on the SteerCo of the Diageo global digital transformation initiative. She is a member of the Board of Governors of the Advertising Standards Council of India and has served on the National Board of AmCham in India.

As with almost all successful professional journeys, hers is built on the foundation of a strong value system, "and it begins with aspiration, action (taking risks and stepping out of comfort zone) and willingness to learn and grow. I used to keep pushing myself to never give up." Encountering similar obstacles that women usually face in their profession, be it balancing work with motherhood or breaking traditional barriers, Hina ploughed on. Her purpose is to live a life of impact and meaning. ■

–Chumki Bharadwaj

LIFE LESSON

"Opportunities present themselves to those who are willing to take them"

HER BEST ADVICE

Be fearless, speak up and don't hesitate to try the impossible... women in leadership roles should choose a company with a progressive work culture